EPISTEMIC BLINDNESS TO MEMORY LOSS AND THE FRAGILITY OF PERSONAL IDENTITY

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Abstract. This paper examines a fundamental paradox at the heart of cognitive science and the philosophy of personal identity. If the loss of memory in an individual is subjectively undetectable at the moment it occurs, then no individual possesses a reliable internal mechanism for verifying the continuity of the self. Building on Lockean memory theory, Schechtman's narrative identity framework, and clinical evidence from confabulation and anosognosia, the paper argues that the conventional assumption, that we know who we are because we remember who we were, is epistemically untenable. If we cannot detect the erasure of our own memories, and if the brain actively fabricates coherent narratives to conceal these gaps, then personal identity is not a verifiable archive but an unverifiable present-tense performance.

Keywords: personal identity, memory loss, epistemic blindness, confabulation, anosognosia, narrative self, Locke, philosophy of mind.

1. Introduction

Every morning, the average person wakes up and knows, without hesitation, who they are. They remember their name, their relationships, their history, and their plans. This continuity of selfhood is so intuitively obvious that it is rarely examined. Yet it must be examined, because the very mechanism upon which this certainty rests, human memory, is not only fallible but is fallible in a way that is, by its own nature, invisible to the person it is failing.

The central paradox of this paper can be stated plainly. If a person loses a memory, they do not experience the loss of that memory; they simply do not have it. There is no alarm, no dark spot, no felt absence. The tape is edited silently. The person wakes up, surveys the interior of their mind, and finds it coherent. They feel continuous. They feel like themselves. But what if they are not? What if substantial portions of who they were have been quietly deleted, and the brain, ever eager to maintain narrative coherence, has written over the gap with plausible fiction?

This is not merely a philosophical thought experiment. It is the daily reality of millions of individuals living with conditions such as Korsakoff's syndrome, early-stage Alzheimer's disease, and anterograde amnesia. Yet the implications reach far beyond clinical populations. If we accept, as the evidence demands, that memory loss is subjectively undetectable, and that the brain confabulates to conceal its own gaps, then the epistemological crisis applies to every human being, not only to those with diagnosed conditions. We may all be confabulating. We may all be performing a self we can no longer fully substantiate.

This paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 examines the foundational Lockean account of personal identity through memory. Section 3 introduces the narrative identity theory of Marya Schechtman and

its implications for the self as story. Section 4 confronts the clinical evidence for confabulatory and anosognosic phenomena and their philosophical consequences. Section 5 develops the central argument: the Unknowable Gap Thesis. Section 6 addresses the objection from the social or distributed self. Section 7 explores the Last Thursday Hypothesis as the logical extreme of the paradox. Section 8 offers a resolution and conclusion, arguing for a reformed understanding of identity as interrogation rather than archive.

2. The Lockean Foundation

The philosophical foundation for linking personal identity to memory was established long ago by John Locke in his *Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (1689). For Locke, personal identity is constituted by the continuity of consciousness, and consciousness extends backward through time precisely through the mechanism of memory. To be the same person as the child who once burned their hand on a stove is to remember burning that hand. Where memory does not reach, personal identity does not reach.

This framework has intuitive appeal. We do not hold people morally responsible for actions they genuinely cannot remember, not merely because we are charitable, but because there is a genuine philosophical sense in which the person who committed the act and the person standing before us may not be the same. Courts of law, in their treatment of severe amnesia, implicitly operate on a Lockean assumption.

However, Locke's theory rests on an assumption that it never examines, but that this paper will expose. Locke assumes that a person can know the extent of their own memory. He assumes that if you cannot remember something, you know that you cannot remember it, that the limit of memory is itself perceivable. This is precisely the assumption that the clinical and neurological evidence destroys.

If personal identity requires an unbroken chain of memory, and if we cannot know whether our chain of memory is broken or not, then we cannot know whether we possess a personal identity in the Lockean sense at all. The criterion of identity is rendered epistemically inaccessible to the very beings it is meant to describe.

3. The Narrative Self

A more sophisticated account of identity is offered by Marya Schechtman in *The Constitution of Selves* (1996), where she argues that what constitutes personal identity is not a chain of memory-links alone but the construction of an autobiographical narrative, a coherent, authored story of one's life. Schechtman distinguishes between the reidentification question (Is this the same biological organism over time?) and the characterization question (Who is this person; what are her values, habits, fears, and commitments?). The latter, she argues, is the question that actually matters for personal identity as we live it.

On this view, the self is less like a database and more like a novel in progress. Every day, new chapters are written. Old chapters are reread and reinterpreted. The character of the protagonist evolves. This is a richer account than Locke's in several respects: it accommodates the fact that memory is reconstructive and interpretive, not merely reproductive.

But this narrative account also faces the same core vulnerability that this paper is tracing. A writer who does not know that pages have been torn from their book cannot know that the story is incomplete. They will read the remaining pages, find them coherent enough, and believe the story is whole. The

narrative self, no less than the Lockean memory-chain self, depends on an undetectable completeness. If chapters have been silently removed and the gaps papered over with confabulated prose, the person is not the author of a coherent self; they are the unwitting reader of an edited one.

Schechtman's account, therefore, does not escape the paradox but deepens it. It is precisely because the self is a narrative, because it requires coherence and story-logic, that the brain's tendency to confabulate is so insidious. Confabulation does not merely fill a gap; it actively repairs the narrative, ensuring that the author never notices the excision.

4. Clinical Evidence

4.1 The Phenomenon of Confabulation

Confabulation is the production of fabricated, distorted, or misinterpreted memories without any conscious intention to deceive. It is not lying; the person who confabulates believes what they are saying. They are not aware that the memory is false, because the brain has generated it with the same phenomenological weight as a genuine memory. It feels remembered because the brain cannot distinguish between what it actually stored and what it has reconstructed.

Confabulation is most commonly observed in patients with Korsakoff's syndrome, a neurological condition caused by severe thiamine deficiency and often associated with chronic alcoholism. These patients suffer profound anterograde amnesia. They cannot form new long-term memories, but they do not sit in silence. Instead, their brain generates elaborate and fluent accounts of their recent activities, accounts that are entirely fictitious, and they defend these accounts with complete confidence (Sacks, 1985).

The philosopher Lisa Bortolotti, in her work on epistemic innocence, has studied confabulation extensively (Bortolotti, 2009, 2016). She notes that confabulated beliefs function to maintain a coherent self-narrative in the absence of the genuine memories that would otherwise constitute it. There is a deep irony here. The cognitive process that is supposed to serve truth-tracking is being used to generate fictions in the service of narrative integrity.

4.2 Anosognosia: Not Knowing What You Do Not Know

Anosognosia is the clinical term for a lack of awareness of one's own deficit or illness. A patient with severe left-side paralysis following a stroke may sincerely deny that anything is wrong with their left arm. When confronted with evidence, for instance when asked to lift the arm and the arm does not move, they may confabulate an excuse (arthritis, tiredness, a choice not to comply) rather than acknowledge the paralysis. They are not being dishonest. The deficit in self-knowledge is neurological.

Applied to memory, anosognosia means that patients in the early and middle stages of Alzheimer's disease frequently do not know they are forgetting. They do not experience their recall as impaired. They do not feel the gaps. This is not denial in the psychological sense; it is a failure of the metacognitive machinery that would ordinarily monitor and report on the accuracy of one's own memory.

The philosophical consequence is devastating. If we cannot know that we have lost memory, even when we have lost significant quantities of it, and if the brain actively confabulates to conceal the loss, then introspection is not a reliable guide to the state of one's memory. We cannot look inward and determine whether we are experiencing the world through a complete or a partial self.

4.3 The Broader Application: Normal Forgetting

One might object that confabulation and anosognosia are clinical extremes, irrelevant to the normal population. But this objection fails on two grounds. First, the mechanisms involved, namely reconstructive memory, confabulation under uncertainty, and metacognitive limits, are not unique to pathological populations. They operate, in subtler degrees, in all humans. Normal memory is reconstructive, not reproductive (Tulving, 2002). Normal people confabulate constantly, filling the gaps of imperfect recall with plausible inferences without being aware of doing so.

Second, and more importantly, the paradox does not require clinical severity to bite. It requires only that some memories are lost without the person's awareness, a condition that applies to every human being who has ever forgotten a dream, a conversation, a year of childhood, or the name of someone they once knew well. The question is not whether we lose memories without awareness. We do. The question is what this means for our ability to verify who we are.

5. The Central Argument: The Unknowable Gap Thesis

We are now in a position to state the central argument of this paper formally. It runs as follows.

Premise 1: Personal identity, on the most plausible accounts, is constituted by, or requires, the continuity of memory.

Premise 2: The loss of a memory is not experienced as a loss; there is no phenomenological marker, no felt absence, no internal signal that a memory has been deleted.

Premise 3: The brain actively confabulates, generating memories that are false but felt as true in order to conceal the gaps left by lost memories, and this process is not transparent to introspection.

Premise 4: Therefore, no individual has reliable introspective access to the state of their own memory chain.

Conclusion: Therefore, no individual can reliably verify their own personal identity through introspection alone.

This is the Unknowable Gap Thesis. It does not claim that people have no identity, or that identity is impossible. It claims something more precisely unsettling: that whatever identity a person has, they cannot fully know it from the inside. The archive is inaccessible to the archivist.

The discovery of memory loss is always retrospective and externally prompted, and this fact becomes philosophically loaded in the present context. We only learn that we have lost a memory when an external cue, a photograph, a diary entry, the testimony of another person, reveals the gap to us. Note, too, that an individual cannot rely on the verification of another individual, since that other person is equally human and equally subject to the same limitations. Moreover, the gap that has been revealed is only the gap we happen to have been prompted about. The vastness of the forgotten, the galaxy of losses we have never been prompted about, remains entirely invisible.

This means that our felt sense of being continuous, coherent selves is not evidence of actual continuity. It is merely evidence that the confabulation engine is working. The feeling of identity is preserved precisely by the mechanism that obscures its possible absence.

6. The Social Self Objection and Its Limits

A natural objection to the Unknowable Gap Thesis is that it focuses too narrowly on individual, internal memory. Surely, the objector says, I am not only the sum of my own recollections. I exist in the memories of others. My family remembers my childhood. My friends remember our conversations. My colleagues remember my past work. Even if my own internal archive is incomplete, the distributed network of social memory constitutes and preserves who I am.

This is the view sometimes called the Distributed Self, or the Extended Mind theory of identity, and it has genuine philosophical merit. The sociologist Maurice Halbwachs argued early in the twentieth century that memory is fundamentally collective (Halbwachs, 1992), that individuals remember within social frameworks that shape, sustain, and correct their recollections. More recent work in extended cognition theory, by Andy Clark and David Chalmers, suggests that cognitive processes, including memory, can extend beyond the brain into the environment, including the social environment (Clark and Chalmers, 1998).

The social self objection, however, faces three decisive problems in the context of this paper. The first is the interiority problem. Even if others remember who I was, I have lost access to that person's inner life: their intentions, their felt experiences, their private reasoning. The person whom others remember is a character in their stories, observed from the outside. The person that I am, or was, is constituted partly by what it was like to be me. If I cannot access those states, then what others remember is a public shadow of a private subject, not the subject itself.

The second is the verification problem. The people on whom I would rely to verify my memory are themselves subject to confabulation. They cannot reliably verify the state of their own memories, let alone mine, so leaning on them for identity verification merely relocates the problem rather than solving it.

The third is the updating problem. If my memory loss is severe or progressive, then my internal sense of who I am may be temporally mislocated. I may believe myself to be the person I was in 2015, while those around me are interacting with my 2026 body. The self they know is a stranger to me. The self I know is inaccessible to them. There is no point of overlap. The social scaffold can preserve the external record of an identity, but it cannot give the subject access to a self they have lost the ability to remember.

7. The Last Thursday Hypothesis of the Self

The Unknowable Gap Thesis has a further and more radical implication that is worth drawing out explicitly, even if its role is more heuristic than argumentative. Philosophers familiar with the literature on external-world skepticism will recognize the structure of the following thought experiment.

Consider that you cannot verify, through introspection alone, that your memories are accurate records of actual past events rather than implanted records of events that never happened. This is, of course, a version of the classical Cartesian demon problem (Descartes, 1641) applied to memory. But the clinical evidence gives it a new and concrete force. We know that the brain can generate false memories indistinguishable from true ones. We know that confabulation produces felt-as-genuine memories of entirely fictitious events. Therefore, the felt sense of having a past does not guarantee the accuracy of that past.

Now suppose, and this is the Last Thursday Hypothesis, that you were constituted last Thursday with

all your current memories fully intact, including the memory of worrying about memory loss, the memory of reading philosophy, the memory of every relationship and experience you believe yourself to have had. Nothing in your introspective experience could distinguish this from the genuine article. The film of your life plays smoothly regardless of whether the events it depicts actually occurred.[1]

The purpose of this hypothesis is not to argue that we were all literally created last Thursday. Its purpose is to demonstrate that the feeling of continuous identity is entirely decoupled from the reality of continuous identity. The phenomenology of selfhood is generated moment to moment by the brain's narrative machinery, and this machinery has no reliable access to its own history. It can only report what it currently believes, and what it currently believes is shaped by both genuine memory and confabulated filler in proportions it cannot disclose to us.

8. Resolution: Identity as Interrogation

One might worry that the argument of this paper leads to a kind of paralysis, a self-undermining skepticism in which we can know nothing about who we are and must abandon the project of self-knowledge entirely. This conclusion would be too hasty, and it would misrepresent what the argument actually establishes.

The argument establishes that the self cannot be known as a complete, verified archive. It does not establish that the self does not exist. The self is real as a present-tense activity, as the act of perceiving, reasoning, relating, and questioning that is occurring right now. Whatever memories have been lost, whatever gaps have been papered over, the self that is engaging with this argument at this moment is undeniably here. It is precisely its uncertainty about its own past that makes it a self rather than a mere recording.

This suggests a reformed conception of personal identity: not the noun of an accumulated archive, but the verb of an ongoing interrogation. The self is not the sum of what it can remember. The self is the act of asking. When René Descartes (1641) famously wrote that the one thing he could not doubt was the existence of the doubter, *cogito ergo sum*, I think therefore I am, he was gesturing at precisely this structure. The thinking, doubting, questioning thing cannot doubt its own existence, because doubting is itself a form of existing.

Applying this to the paradox of unknowable memory loss: even if we cannot know who we were, we cannot be nothing, because the question "Who am I?" is being asked, and asking it requires an asker. The paradox does not dissolve personal identity; it relocates it from the domain of memory and archive to the domain of present awareness and persistent inquiry.

This resolution also carries a practical and ethical implication. If identity cannot be fully known from the inside through memory, then the ethics of how we treat people with memory loss must be reconsidered. We should not treat such persons as diminished selves simply because their archives are compromised. The activity of selfhood, responding, relating, experiencing, questioning, continues in them even when the archive is severely damaged. The person who cannot remember yesterday's lunch is still, in the most important sense, someone.

[1] This predicament is dramatized in Christopher Nolan's film *Memento* (Nolan, 2000), whose protagonist, unable to form new memories, must reconstruct his identity and his past entirely from external notes, photographs, and tattoos.

9. Conclusion

This paper has traced a paradox from its philosophical origins in Locke's memory theory, through the narrative identity account of Schechtman, into the clinical territory of confabulation and anosognosia, and out the other side to a reformed understanding of the self. The paradox is this: if personal identity requires the continuity of memory, and if memory loss is subjectively undetectable, indeed if the brain actively works to conceal memory loss from the very consciousness it serves, then no person can reliably verify their own personal identity.

We are, in a very precise sense, unreliable narrators of our own lives. The feeling of continuity is preserved by the same mechanism that makes continuity unknowable: the brain's relentless commitment to narrative coherence. We do not experience the gaps. We experience only the patched and edited version that the brain presents to us, with no footnotes indicating where the original text has been altered.

And yet this is not cause for despair. The self that cannot know its own archive is still a self, perhaps more genuinely and more importantly a self than the self that believes its archive is complete. For the questioning self, the self that does not take its own continuity for granted, is a self that is alive to the actual conditions of human existence: finite, fallible, perpetually reconstructing itself from incomplete materials, and doing so in full view of its own uncertainty.

Who are you? You are the one who is asking. And that, it turns out, is enough to be someone.

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